Q | A

BATTING FOR EQUALITY

As the most expensive player of the Women's Premier League, all eyes are on Royal Challengers Bangalore captain ***Smriti Mandhana***

Q. It's been a long wait for the Women's Premier League (WPL). What are your expectations from this tournament?
The WPL is definitely the next big step for women's cricket in India. We've seen what the Indian Premier League has done for men's cricket and I am hoping the same happens for us in the time ahead. You can see how excited people are and how they've accepted women's cricket. So, yes, I am really looking forward to the first edition of the WPL.

Q. You will be leading the Royal Challengers Bangalore (RCB) team. How much do you enjoy the role of a captain?
I have led domestic teams since the age of 16, so captaincy is not something new for me. I would like to use all those experiences and also what I've learnt as part of the senior leadership group in the Indian team to lead RCB in the best possible way.

Q. Is there pressure on you as the most expensive player of the league?
Well, not really. Even when we were watching the auction, we never really thought about the price tag. As female cricketers, we are just happy that this is finally happening for women's cricket.

Q. How do you see the WPL helping women's cricket in India?
I'm happy that so many girls have started playing cricket over the last four-five years. When I go to my hometown, Sangli, I see girls playing alongside boys on the under-14 sides. It makes me proud that so many of them are picking up the bat and ball and want to play professional cricket. I'm sure a lot of parents will make their girls dream of playing in the WPL and for India someday.

with Shail Desai



MANDAR DEODHAR